



20th World Congress of the European Association for Palliative Care

Palliative Care Research: From strong foundations to new horizons

14 - 16 May 2026
Prague, Czech Republic



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Mapping voluntary financial
support services in England
and Wales: **Understanding
the barriers and facilitators
to access**

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Association between financial insecurity and terminal illness

“Financial insecurity refers to when an individual encounters objective difficulty or subjective distress when trying to cover necessary financial expenses.”²

In 2024, more than 100,000 people died in poverty in the UK¹

23% of terminally ill patients report experiencing high levels of financial insecurity²

A single person of working age has a weekly benefits income of **under £400**³

“Existing government support is **not enough to meet these costs**, and there is an unsustainable reliance on under-pressure voluntary support”³

Reducing/stopping employment

Transport to appointments

Care costs

Regular household costs

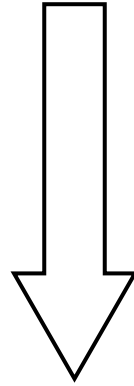
Medical equipment

Financial Insecurity

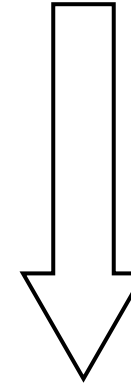
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Identify the sources of one-off grants in England and Wales and understand the barriers and facilitators to accessing them



- Systematic review of charities registered in England and Wales (n=5,783)
- Online survey sent to collect information regarding the availability of and application process for financial support
- Mapping the geographical distribution of this financial support



- Focus groups (n=3) conducted with social workers and clinicians to shape questions asked in qualitative interviews
- Semi-structured interviews with patients (n=3), social workers (n=4), and charity providers (n=4)

Where charities provide help varies greatly

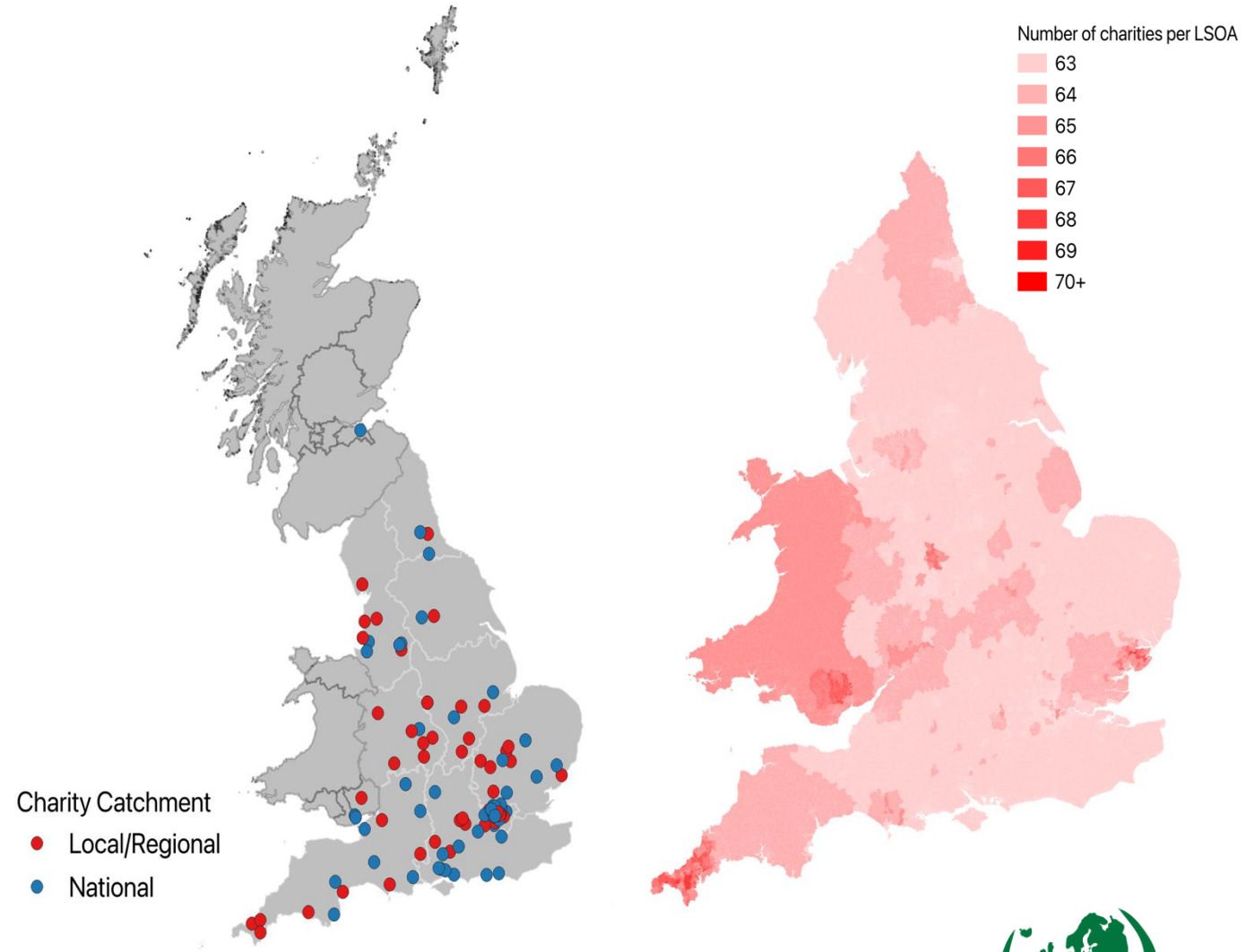
From 5,866 charities initially identified in the charity register:

- 5,313 were contacted
- 470 replied to our invitation to participate
- **123** submitted complete survey responses

18 (15%) charities provided grants specifically for those with a terminal illness.

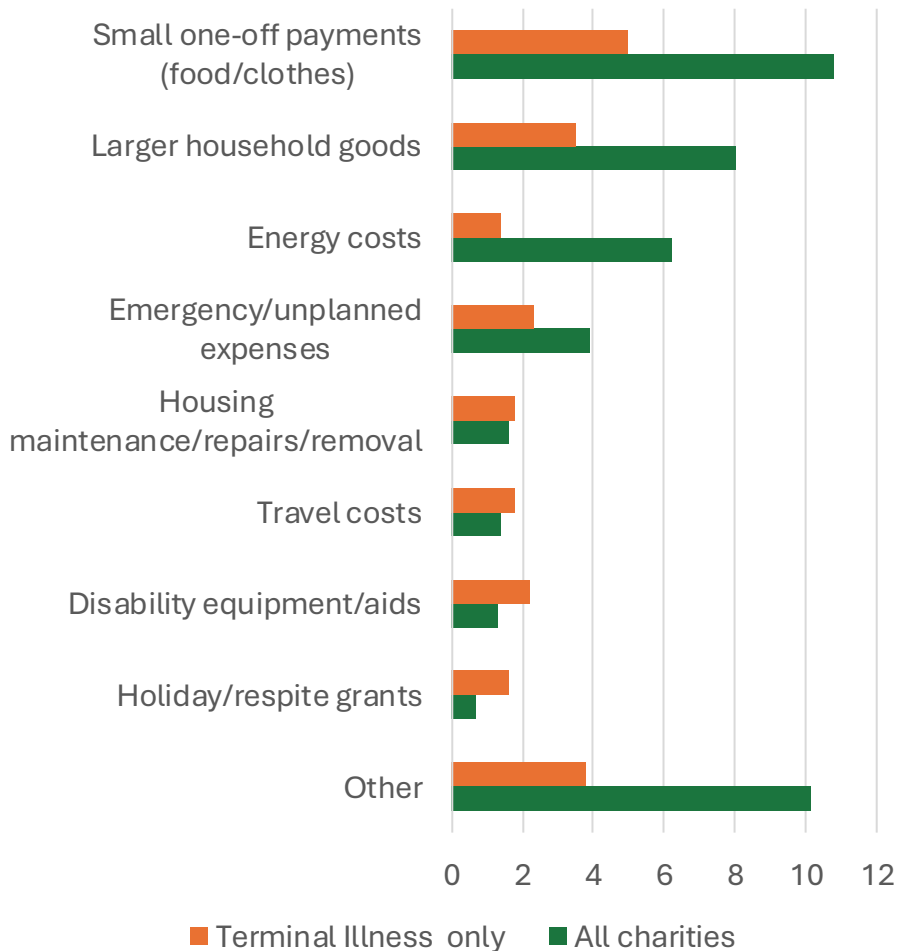
- A slight majority operated nationally across England and Wales (n=64; 52%)
- Heterogeneity in how catchment areas are defined for local charities; most align with administrative boundaries (n=41)

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Charities are not getting enough applications

Mean Weekly Applications by Grant Type



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How many applications do charities receive?

<i>Applications per week</i>	<i>N (%)</i>
0 - 5	85 (69%)
6 – 10	12 (10%)
11 or more	25 (20%)
No data	1 (1%)
Total	123 (100%)

Analysis of application forms (n=32):

- Average N^o pages = 3.5 [range: 1-16]
- Most require at least a paragraph justifying the application (n=21; 67%) and some require supporting documentation (n=6;19%)
- A slight majority (54%) of forms could be completed by the applicant themselves with **41% requiring third-party mediation**

“...it's almost sometimes you know that they they're **squeezing every bit of information out** before they'll give something like a tumble dryer...” [Social Worker 1]

“...**we do have the money to fund more. But we just don't get that many applications.** And the trustees regularly talk about is there something more we could do to attract people?” [Charity provider 3]

Applications, when made, are mostly successful

The **median application success rate** over the last 12 months was **88%** [IQR: 72%-97%]

72 (83.7%) charities have **specific criteria** for assessing application outcomes. These include:

- **Financial need (n=22; 18%)**
- **Residence (n=22; 18%)**
- Profession (n=19; 15%)
- Applicant health status (n=9; 7%)
- Age (n=6; 5%)
- External referral (n=4; 3%)
- Family member profession (n=2; 2%)

“...when they're in the final weeks and sometimes it's almost like **you don't have enough time to apply** because a lot of the charities they take so long” [Social Worker 2]

“The problem with our charity is we only meet quarterly, **so if you're terminally ill, that may not be much good to you, frankly.**” [Charity provider 1]

“...and we applied for that and I had an e-mail four nights ago to say, ‘yes, you covered all the criteria, we'll put you on the list for 2030’...and I thought, **will I be here in 2030?**” [Patient 2]

“It's **life changing** for me. So, you know, my life would just be all the worse if I didn't have it” [Patient 1]

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Charity support is available but not being accessed



Scan for links to
further reading
on this project

Why is this the case?

- Unclear and strict criteria
- Application processes that are hard to manage
- Timeframe of application decisions not matching up to terminal illness prognosis

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¹Marie Curie. (2025). *Dying in poverty 2025* [Report]. Marie Curie. <https://www.mariecurie.org.uk/document/dying-in-poverty-report-2025>

²Walker-Pow, R., Bruun, A., Kupeli, N., Bosco, A., & White, N. (2024). *A systematic review on the impact of financial insecurity on the physical and psychological well-being for people living with terminal illness*. Palliative Medicine. <https://doi.org/10.1177/02692163241257583>

³All-Party Parliamentary Group for Hospice and End of Life Care. (2025, September 9). *Inquiry into the financial impact of a terminal diagnosis*.

